Introduction to Dual Language Immersion in Georgia

This presentation will:

- Provide an overview of Dual Language Immersion (DLI) in Georgia.
- Highlight the benefits of DLI for students and families.
- Describe the different DLI program models in Georgia.
- Explain how DLI programs support English Learners.
- Share the history of DLI in Georgia and showcase current programs.

What is Dual Language Immersion?

Dual Language Immersion (DLI) is an educational program in which students are taught literacy and content in two languages. The goal is to develop bilingualism, biliteracy, academic achievement, and cross-cultural competencies. It is a model that fosters high levels of proficiency in both the target language and English.

In Georgia, subjects like math and science might be taught in Spanish while social studies and English language arts are taught in English. Students have two teachers – a Spanish language teacher and an English language teacher.

A History of DLI in Georgia

- 2007 – The First DLI Charter School in Georgia was established at Unidos Dual Language School in Clayton County.
- 2008 – The first non-charter public DLI program was established at Beulah ES in Douglas County.
- 2009 – The World Language Academy was established in Hall County.
- 2013-2024 – DLI programs were established in 87 schools.

What are the benefits of DLI?

- **Cognitive Benefits**
  - Enhances problem-solving, memory, and multitasking skills.
- **Academic Advantages**
  - Students in DLI programs often perform as well as or better than their peers in traditional programs on standardized tests.
- **Language Proficiency**
  - Students achieve higher levels of proficiency in the target language compared to traditional language programs.
- **Career Readiness**
  - Provides students with skills valuable language skills for the workplace.

DLI Instructional Model (PreK-5)

Typically, instruction is divided equally between the two languages (50:50). This approach allows students to learn content and language simultaneously in both languages.

At each grade level (PreK-5), two teachers work together to share the responsibility of teaching their students across two languages.

The English-side instructor teaches reading, writing, and social studies in English. The target language instructor typically teaches math, science, and literacy in the target language.

Districts may assess DLI students to determine proficiency growth in the target language.

DLI Instructional Model (6-12)

- In middle school DLI programs, students may participate in “bridge” programs with courses that focus on strengthening proficiency in the target language. Some schools offer content (such as math or science) taught in the target language.
- High school DLI continuation programs culminate in advanced coursework such as Advanced Placement or International Baccalaureate language and literature courses. Students in these programs may also be eligible to earn the Georgia Seal of Biliteracy.

Who are the students in DLI?

In a Two-Way DLI program, students are a combination of native English speakers and native speakers of the target language in the same classroom, providing balanced exposure and interaction in both languages.

In a One-Way DLI program, most students share the same first language (usually English) and are learning a second language.

In Georgia, programs across the state provide instruction in languages like Spanish, French, German, Japanese, Korean, and Mandarin, with an emphasis on bilingualism and academic success.

What are the admission requirements for DLI programs?

The success and operation of DLI programs are determined by each Local Education Agency (LEA). They have the responsibility to create policies and procedures tailored to their community's needs while ensuring alignment with state and federal guidelines. This allows flexibility in program design, staffing, and language instruction to meet local goals.

DLI admission requirements will also vary. Families should inquire with the district or charter school in which they are interested to learn about attendance zone admissions, specialty program applications, lottery processes, etc.

How does DLI work for English Learners?

Since 2015, the DLI program has been a state-approved ESOL delivery model in Georgia (State Board of Education Rule IDDG 160-4-5-.02). Defined as “an educational delivery model whereby students learn academic content through both their native language and a foreign language”, the DLI/ESOL delivery model requires that English Learner “students participating in a DLI program receive their supplemental English language support from the teacher providing English instruction during the English portion of the academic day.”

DLI Programs in Georgia

In Georgia, local districts have the flexibility to decide whether to establish DLI programs. There is no statewide mandate requiring districts of offer DLI. Each district evaluates factors such as community demand, availability of resources, and alignment with district goals.

Families interested in DLI should inquire with their local school district about program availability.

In additional to public schools, some charter schools in Georgia also offer DLI programs as part of their unique educational missions.

DLI Programs in Georgia

The following districts and charter schools offer DLI:

- Atlanta Public Schools
- Clarke County Schools
- Clayton County Schools
- Cobb County Schools
- Crisp County Schools
- Dalton Public Schools
- DeKalb County Schools
- Forsyth County Schools
- Fulton County Schools
- Gwinnett County Schools
- Hall County Schools
- Marietta City Schools
- Rockdale County Schools
- Savannah-Chatham County Schools
- International Charter Academy of Georgia
- International Charter School of Atlanta
- The GLOBE Academy
- Yi Hwang Academy of Language Excellence

